

because Nebuchadnezzar had shattered Israel. The writer put this prediction into the mouth of Jeremiah, and declared that this man of God wrote it during the fourth year of Zedekiah's reign." This view makes the whole prophecy a deliberate forgery, and not only worthless but detestable.

More reverent critics satisfy themselves with calling the writer anonymous; an affirmation directly contrary to the Bible, which states repeatedly that the writer was Jeremiah. A recognition of that prophet as the author is incompatible with any theory that would limit such predictions to nearly approaching events. But to call the prophecy anonymous is a misapplication of language, for its author could not be named either more expressly or more fully; and if it was not written by Jeremiah, the circumstantial narrative of its origin and history cannot have been a mistake, but is a deliberate falsehood embodied in the sacred writings.

For the existence of such anonymous prophets, either one or several, in Babylon during the exile there is not the faintest trace of historical proof, either as regards the prophets themselves, or the effect of their writings on the people at the time, or on the memories of the nation. Confessedly there is no such evidence outside the Bible; and the Bible itself, as we have seen, gives no ground and leaves no room for the supposition. The Scriptural prophecies against Babylon, far from being nameless, are expressly assigned to two of the greatest names in the roll of the prophets, Isaiah and Jeremiah; and there is not the slightest intimation of the existence of a single anonymous prophet in Babylon. At the beginning of the exile there were false prophets there; and their names are not only recorded, but were handed down with a note of infamy in the lips of the exiles. In the period of Exile there lived two great prophets in Babylon, Ezekiel and Daniel, one in the city, and the other in the kingdom; their names are attached to their prophecies, and have come down to us among the great prophets of Scripture. Of anonymous prophets in Babylon, either one or more, either true or false, Scripture acknowledges none.